DUCK, WILD RICE, AND CRANBERRY SAUSAGE PATTIES

WITH POACHED DUCK EGGS AND DANDELION CHIMICHURRI

serves 4

Ducks and wild rice share a special relationship. According to an Anishinaabe legend, a passing duck dropped wild rice into a kettle and introduced this life-sustaining grain to people. During the harvest season, people allow some of the rice grains to fall into the water to share with duck relatives, and to help plant next year's crop.

To make these free-form sausage patties, it's easiest to start with ground duck meat. If you can't find it, you can certainly grind your own. Just make sure 10 to 20 percent of the weight includes the fat or skin, so the patties will be juicy.

CHIMICHURRI

- 4 ounces dandelion leaves (tough stems removed), finely chopped
- ½ shallot, finely chopped
- 1 tablespoon dried cranberries, preferably unsweetened, finely chopped
- 2 tablespoons cider vinegar
- ⅓ cup sunflower oil
- Sea salt

PATTIES AND EGGS

- 3 juniper berries
- 1 pound ground duck meat
- 1 cup cooked and chilled wild rice (from ⅓ cup uncooked rice; see page 83)
- ⅓ cup dried cranberries, preferably unsweetened, finely chopped
- 1¼ teaspoons dried wild bergamot (bee balm)
- 1½ teaspoons fine sea salt
- 4 duck eggs
- 1 tablespoon sunflower oil
- Ground sumac, for sprinkling (optional)

Make the chimichurri: In a medium bowl, stir together the chopped dandelion, shallot, and cranberries. Stir in the vinegar and sunflower oil. Taste and season with salt.

Make the patties and eggs: Use a small mortar to pound the juniper berries into a powder.

In a large bowl, mix together the ground duck, chilled wild rice, cranberries, bergamot, crushed juniper, and salt. Using a ½-cup measuring cup or scoop, form the sausage into 8 patties of equal size, about ½ inch thick and place them on a plate.

One at a time, crack each egg into a fine-mesh sieve set over a bowl to allow any of the extra loose egg white to drain. Transfer each cracked egg to its own small bowl.

Bring a medium pot of water to a bare simmer over medium-low heat. Stir the water to create a vortex and add 2 of the eggs, one at a time, and cook for about 3 minutes, or just until the white is opaque and the yolk is still soft. Using a slotted spoon, transfer to a plate and repeat with the remaining 2 eggs. Keep the eggs near the stove so they stay warm.

In a large skillet, heat the oil over medium-high heat until shimmering. Add the sausage patties and cook for 3 to 4 minutes, until browned on the bottom. Flip, reduce the heat to medium, and cook for about 3 minutes, or until browned on the bottom and cooked through or until an instant-read thermometer inserted into the side of a sausage registers 165°F.

Transfer the sausage to plates and serve with the poached duck eggs and dandelion chimichurri. Sprinkle with sumac, if desired.